Hirohito and his son Akihito instead served as an accompanying symbolic note to Japan's reconstruction and emergence as an economic superpower. Postwar pacifism, the fruit of an alliance between the Left and the Right, was firmly embedded in the country, but Japan's essentially conservative social and cultural structures also remained intact, except for large-scale landowning, a victim of the occupation. Against all odds, the imperial family became identified as a fundamental element of stability anchoring a country once again rapidly modernizing.

Judging Modern Japan

As the persistence of the imperial system and the invented tradition surrounding it shows, the Japanese have always viewed modernity warily. They have forged their own path, one that has brought as much criticism as praise. After more than two decades of being dismissed, perhaps it is time to reconsider the long-tainted "Japan model."

At least in Western eyes, Japan has spent the past three decades under a cloud. After the Japanese asset price bubble popped in the late 1980s, the once-and-future Pacific superpower no longer interested investors, pundits, or the media. So-called Japanese models such as lifetime employment, so recently lauded, were quickly reinterpreted as rigidity, risk averseness, and a general inability to deal with a new era of innovation that valued the individual over the group. In particular, it became an article of faith in the West to decry Japan's insularity, whether economic or sociocultural. Japanese society, ethnically monolithic and anti-immigration, was derided as fatally parochial in the new, modern, borderless world.

Japan has found a separate existence—a separate peace if you will—from the globalization paradigm that has dominated the West since World War II. The country's experience over the past quarter century, since the popping of the asset and real estate bubble in 1989, raises a challenge to the fundamental question of Western modernity: How